



Top buy: Indian defender Uditā became the most expensive player at the Women's Hockey India League auction. Known for her solid defence and attacking versatility, she brings immense value to Shrachi Rarh Bengal Tigers. **RV MOORTHY**

In its efforts to popularise the sport across the country, Hockey India has decided to forego the revenue it would have generated from ticket sales by making entry across the men's and women's competitions free for all.

learning a lot since it is the first time that a league of this scale is being organised," says Ishika Chaudhary, Odisha Warriors (ODWA) defender and the first player to have been sold at the women's auction for Rs 16 lakh.

The 'scale' Ishika mentions could have been grander had the plans of including two more teams not been

deferred until the next season. After the closure of certain legal proceedings, it was announced that the Hyderabad Toofans and a franchise of the BC Jindal Group, Mumbai, will be invited to the party only in 2025-26.

While the official statement may have been the harbinger of good

news for the competitive nature of what is now a four-team league, it might make life difficult for the new franchises, who would have to string together a squad from a depleted pool.

Presently, 96 players have been slotted into the Delhi SG Pipers (DSGP), JSW Soorma Hockey Club